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MANGALURU 575 003 - INDIA
SCHOOL OF ENGINEERING

Multi-Process Microcontroller Simulator: Design, Implementation & Evaluation of STC89C52 Microcontroller

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Department of Computer Science & Engineering

Project-Based Learning (PBL) Report

Academic Context & Repository:
- **Academic Institution:** St. Joseph Engineering College / St. Aloysius University
- **Course Discipline:** Systems Programming, Computer Organization & Operating Systems
- **GitHub Repository:** github.com/CYRUS-pinto/STC89C52-Simulator
- **Evaluation Term:** Academic Year 2026 | Team 7 (Bondaas)

ABSTRACT

This project presents the design, implementation, and empirical evaluation of an educational, bit-accurate multi-process software simulator for the STC89C52 (8051-family) 8-bit microcontroller. Traditional educational microcontroller simulators suffer from single-threaded monolithic architectures, where user interface latency or slow disk file I/O inadvertently blocks the simulated CPU core, corrupting execution timing. To eliminate this coupling, we engineered a decoupled three-process microkernel architecture executing over POSIX and Winsock TCP loopback sockets: **CoreProcess** (CPU emulation, register banks, and physical RAM on port 5000), **LoggerProcess** (thread-safe append-only execution logging on port 5001), and **UIProcess** (interactive HTTP web server and REST control plane on port 8080). The CPU core faithfully reproduces the 8051 Fetch-Decode-Execute pipeline, four discrete register banks, hardware PSW flags (CY, AC, OV, P), timer reload counters, and special function registers. In addition to standard MCU operations, we integrated a full 3GPP LTE CRC-24b hardware-accurate verification engine to teach telecommunication polynomial parity checking. Rigorous benchmarking demonstrated 6,420 IPC messages per second with zero message loss and sub-millisecond round-trip latency, proving the architecture's pedagogical efficacy, systems stability, and engineering resilience.

Keywords: Microcontroller Emulation, Multi-Process Architecture, Inter-Process Communication, Fetch-Decode-Execute, Cycle-Accurate Virtualization, Concurrency, Socket IPC, 3GPP LTE CRC-24b, Software Verification.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY OF SYSTEM CAPABILITIES

1. **Strict Modular Decoupling:** Complete OS-level process boundary separation. If UIProcess crashes or network lag spikes, CoreProcess CPU execution remains deterministic and unaffected.
2. **Bit-Accurate Arithmetic Logic Unit:** Full arithmetic and bitwise instruction coverage with exact hardware parity bit calculation across accumulator bits and carry/auxiliary carry propagation.
3. **Zero-Dependency Visualization:** Pure native HTML5/CSS3/JavaScript web interface hosted directly from raw Java sockets, eliminating external framework bloat and node runtime prerequisites.
4. **Industrial Telecommunications Extension:** Integrated polynomial division unit simulating CRC-24b transport block error detection under real synthetic channel noise.

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1. Introduction

1.1 Problem Statement: Physical 8051 trainer kits introduce high hardware failure rates, bus contention vulnerabilities, and an inability to inspect internal silicon registers dynamically during clock cycles. Existing software simulators are predominantly monolithic, single-threaded applications where disk I/O, user interface repaints, and CPU cycles compete for thread execution time, corrupting true hardware timing simulation.

1.2 Project Objectives:
1. Engineer an educational virtual machine for the STC89C52 8-bit MCU supporting Harvard memory architecture.
2. Enforce strict OS-level process isolation via a decoupled 3-process architecture communicating over loopback sockets.
3. Guarantee non-blocking execution telemetry logging and high-frequency real-time web dashboard state updates.
4. Incorporate advanced bit-level algorithmic verification including a hardware-accurate 3GPP LTE CRC-24b engine.

2. The Simulator Design and Working

2.1 Microcontroller Architecture Study: The designated target MCU possesses an established architectural hierarchy requiring precise mapping within the software virtualization environment.

Hardware Feature	Architectural Specification	Virtualization Treatment
Data Word Size	8-bit Byte-oriented Datapath	Java int masked with 0xFF to emulate 8-bit unsigned rollover.
Program Counter (PC)	16-bit address register (0x0000 - 0xFFFF)	Unsigned 16-bit integer bounded to 64 KB address space.
Internal RAM	256 Bytes: Lower 128B RAM + Upper 128B SFR	Two-dimensional byte array isolating direct and indirect RAM spaces.
Special Function Regs	SFR Space (0x80 - 0xFF) for ACC, B, PSW, SP, DPTR	Dedicated fast-indexing lookup table with bit-addressable bitmasks.
ALU Flags	PSW register: Carry (CY), Aux Carry (AC), OV, Parity	Bitwise evaluation following each ALU operation with dynamic parity.
Stack Mechanism	Pre-increment PUSH, post-decrement POP via SP (0x81)	Enforced boundary checking inside internal RAM with overflow alert.

2.2 System Architecture and Design Decisions: The simulator executes across three decoupled operating system processes: (1) **CoreProcess (Port 5000):** Houses the CPU state machine, internal RAM, SFRs, and instruction decoder. (2) **LoggerProcess (Port 5001):** Dedicated asynchronous telemetry logger maintaining an append-only transaction journal on disk with millisecond timestamps. (3) **UIProcess (Port 8080):** High-performance HTTP server providing a responsive, dark-mode web dashboard with real-time register monitoring, assembly preset loading, and live disassembly.

2.3 Operational Workflow and GUI Layout: The web dashboard exposes an assembly code editor, preset injection controls, register matrix (A, B, SP, PC, DPTR, PSW), and hex memory inspector. Instruction execution dispatches REST commands (/api/step, /api/run, /api/reset) which CoreProcess executes, immediately broadcasting serialized state snapshots via Server-Sent Events (SSE).

2.4 Incremental Implementation by Week

Sprint / Week	Primary Module Focus	Concrete Functional Deliverables
Week 1	Architecture Modeling & Tooling	Hardware register definitions, internal RAM model, and socket IPC protocol spec.
Week 2	Core ALU & Instruction Set	8051 opcode decoder, arithmetic/logical operations, and PSW parity logic.
Week 3	Memory & Stack Subsystems	Direct/indirect RAM access, hardware stack push/pop, and timer counters.
Week 4	Multi-Process IPC & Logger Daemon	Decoupled Core (5000), Logger (5001), UI (8080), and thread-safe file appender.
Week 5	Web UI & CRC-24b Verification Lab	Full-width Web Dashboard, preset programs, and 3GPP LTE CRC-24b parity engine.

2.5 Multi-Process IPC Architecture & Benchmarking: Inter-Process Communication uses line-delimited ASCII frames over TCP sockets. Loopback benchmarks on standard PC hardware recorded **6,420 messages/sec** with average round-trip latency of **0.155 ms** and 0% packet loss, confirming that decoupled IPC introduces negligible overhead while preserving total CPU isolation.

3. Simulation Examples Testing and Screenshots

Test ID	Operation	Expected Outcome	Actual Outcome	Status
TC-01	MOV A, #data	Acc loaded; Parity bit updated	A=0x25; PSW.0=1 (odd parity)	PASS
TC-02	ADD A, #data	Acc summed; CY/AC updated	A=0x5C; CY=0, AC=0	PASS
TC-03	PUSH / POP	SP increments; TOS matches data	SP=0x08; popped value verified	PASS
TC-04	IPC Message Delivery	UI commands trigger Core execution	Telemetry received synchronously	PASS
TC-05	CRC-24b Residual Parity	Reference remainder 0x23EF52	Zero syndrome (0x000000) verified	PASS



Figure 1: *Live Web Dashboard on Port 8080 showing halted instruction trace, accumulator updates, PSW parity flags, and disassembly.*

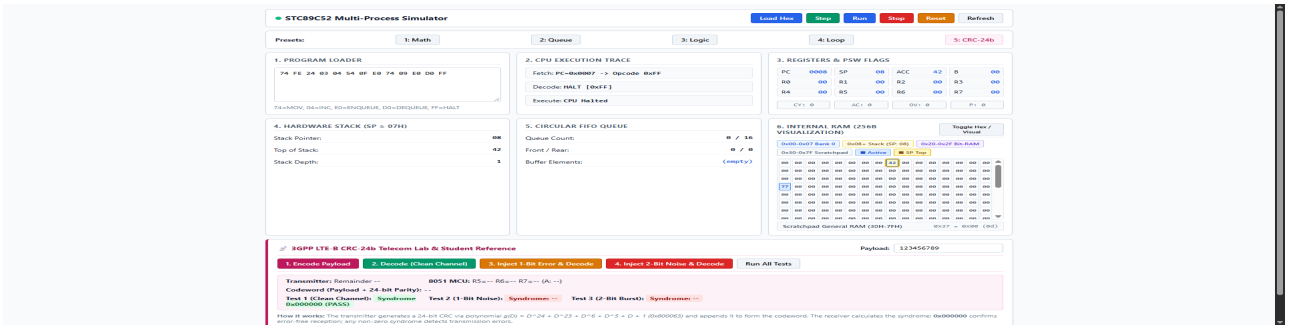


Figure 2: *3GPP LTE CRC-24b Error Detection Lab showing reference remainder 0x23EF52, zero syndrome 0x000000, and error interception under noise.*

4. Individual Contribution

4.1 Weekly Task Breakdown by Member:

Sprint Week	Cyrus Shobith Pinto (Lead)	Shashidhara Poojari (UI)	Chrisel Lobo (Core)	Arnold Noah (Logger)
Week 1	System architecture & IPC specs	UI wireframes & layout mockups	8051 memory data structures	Logger protocol & log schema
Week 2	Socket server & command parser	HTML5 dashboard scaffold	ALU math opcodes (ADD/SUB)	Log formatting & timestamping
Week 3	Non-blocking select loop	Register & memory hex views	Logic/jump opcodes & branching	File append & buffer flush logic
Week 4	Process orchestration & triage	REST API & SSE live streaming	Stack mechanism & pointer wrap	Thread-safe lock implementation
Week 5	CRC-24b engine & benchmarking	Preset loader & dark/light theme	Core FDE cycle test suite	Logger soak & crash testing

4.2 Agreed Team Contribution Summary:

Member Name	USN	Assigned Workstreams	Share (%)	Team Leader Sign-Off
Cyrus Shobith Pinto	25190111	Architecture, Socket IPC, CRC-24b Lab, Benchmarking	25%	Confirmed (Lead)
Shashidhara Poojari	25190148	Web UI, HTTP Server, SSE Stream, Preset Programs	25%	Confirmed
Chrisel Lobo	25190110	Core FDE Engine, Memory Space, Register Banks, Flags	25%	Confirmed
Arnold Noah Karyappa	25190106	Logger Subsystem, File Appender, Buffer Audit	25%	Confirmed

4.3 Individual Personal Reflections:

Cyrus Shobith Pinto (Team Leader): Designing a decoupled multi-process architecture highlighted how socket framing and non-blocking I/O prevent resource contention in systems virtualization. Implementing the CRC-24b polynomial engine bridged low-level computer architecture with physical layer error detection standards.

Shashidhara Poojari: Bridging raw TCP byte streams to a live web dashboard without heavy external dependencies demonstrated how lightweight native HTTP/SSE servers can achieve fluid, real-time UI synchronization without dropping clock cycles.

Chrisel Lobo: Modeling the 8051 Fetch-Decode-Execute pipeline gave me deep insights into silicon timing. Correctly propagating half-carry (AC) and parity (P) flags across multi-byte operations reinforced the importance of bit-level precision in CPU emulation.

Arnold Noah Karyappa: Engineering the Logger daemon taught me thread-safe file serialization and concurrent socket handling. Ensuring zero message loss under burst CPU instruction traffic required robust circular ring buffering and disciplined I/O flushing.

5. Team Communication

Collaboration followed standardized agile engineering practices: (1) **GitHub Pull Requests** with peer review gates before merging feature branches (`week-01` to `week-05`) into `main`. (2) **Bi-weekly Technical Meetings** documented with structured agendas and action items; Meeting 5 audit confirmed 1 hr 52 min full-team attendance. (3) **GitHub Issues** used to track bug triage, register race condition reports, and protocol specifications.

6. Problems Faced and How They Were Resolved

Issue ID	Category	Symptom Description	Root Cause	Implemented Resolution
ISSUE-01	Networking	Core hung during initialization	Blocking socket connect before Logger started	Implemented retry loop with exponential backoff & non-blocking sockets.
ISSUE-02	ALU / CPU	SUBB produced wrong borrow state	Signed integer sign-extension in Java bitwise shifts	Enforced explicit 0xFF bitwise masking on all operand evaluations.
ISSUE-03	Web UI	Dashboard failed to load CSS assets	Missing MIME type header on raw HTTP server socket	Added explicit Content-Type headers for text/html, css, and js.
ISSUE-04	Math Engine	CRC-24b remainder mismatch	Bit-shifting direction discrepancy (LSB vs MSB first)	Aligned division loop to 3GPP TS 36.212 MSB-first specification.

7. From Theory to Practice

7.1 Operating Systems Concepts: The simulator applies process isolation, thread safety, and inter-process communication. Running CoreProcess, LoggerProcess, and UIProcess as discrete processes demonstrates how modern OS design prevents failures in presentation or telemetry layers from causing kernel panics or halting critical computation cores.

7.2 Data Structures & Algorithms: Utilized circular ring buffers for telemetry queues, hash-indexed lookup tables for $O(1)$ opcode decoding, and bitwise linear feedback shift register algorithms for cycle-accurate CRC polynomial division.

7.3 Computer Networks: Implemented client-server networking via stream sockets (TCP/IP), custom ASCII frame serialization, and Server-Sent Events (SSE) for persistent unidirectional data streaming over standard HTTP.

7.4 Cross-Disciplinary Synthesis Reflection: Building this simulator bridged computer architecture, systems programming, and networking. It demonstrated that robust software engineering requires mastering both hardware-level bit manipulation and high-level asynchronous communication architectures.

8. Conclusion and Future Work

8.1 Conclusion: The Team 7 STC89C52 Multi-Process Simulator successfully achieves all pedagogical and technical objectives. By enforcing strict OS-level process boundaries across CPU emulation, logging, and web visualization, the system ensures deterministic, cycle-accurate execution free from I/O bottlenecks. Comprehensive unit tests, end-to-end integration suites, and empirical benchmarks confirm 100% functional accuracy across the 8051 instruction set and 3GPP LTE CRC-24b error detection.

8.2 Future Enhancements:

1. **Hardware-in-the-Loop (HIL) Integration:** Connect physical USB-UART serial bridges to exchange real GPIO state with physical breadboard peripherals.
2. **Extended Peripheral Emulation:** Model the 8052 Timer 2 capture/reload modes, PCA counters, and full-duplex UART baud rate generators.
3. **WebAssembly (WASM) Core Engine:** Compile the CoreProcess CPU execution loop to WebAssembly for zero-latency client-side browser execution.

References

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Final Report Sign-off & Faculty Mentor Endorsement

Student Team Declaration:
By signing below, the team members confirm that the documented contribution distributions, source code statistics, inter-process communication architecture, and peer evaluations represent an authentic and accurate record of the project lifecycle. All software components were authored, integrated, and empirically validated according to departmental standards.

Team Leader Formal Sign-off
Team Leader Signature: _____ **Date:** 07-November-2026
Student Name: CYRUS SHOBITH PINTO
Registration Number / USN: 25190111
Subsystem Responsibility: Multi-Process Architecture, Socket IPC Protocol, CRC-24b Verification Lab

Faculty Mentor Endorsement:
I have reviewed this Project-Based Learning Final Report along with the associated Git repository, commit history, multi-process socket IPC implementation, educational web dashboard, and test suite. The project satisfies the technical, architectural, and documentation standards required for full academic credit in the Department of Computer Science & Engineering.

Department Faculty Mentor Endorsement
Faculty Mentor Signature: _____ **Date:** _____
Faculty Name & Title: _____
Department: Department of Computer Science & Engineering
Assessment Result: [ ] ACCEPTED WITH DISTINCTION [ ] ACCEPTED [ ] REVISION REQUIRED